

MetaHOPE - Framework for the Alignment of Metaphor-Related Words (MRWs) in Translation

Background

The objective of the **word-level** alignment task is to identify how the metaphor-related meaning associated with an MRW is realized in translation. The task focuses on semantic-functional correspondence rather than strict lexical equivalence.

Since metaphor-related meaning is often context-sensitive, semantically rich, and culturally dependent, metaphor translation frequently involves reformulation across linguistic and cultural systems. Therefore, it requires annotation to examine the target text to identify whether there is a target word, phrase, or larger textual unit that realizes the metaphor-related meaning associated with the source MRW.

The alignment framework is informed by translation shift and equivalence literature in Translation Studies, which suggests that translation frequently involves **structural, semantic, and pragmatic reformulation rather than strict formal correspondence** (e.g. Catford, 1965; Baker, 1992; Chesterman, 1997). Particularly, paraphrasing, implicitation, restructuring, semantic reformulation, and pragmatic adaptation are common translational strategies that may affect how metaphor-related meaning is realized in the target text.

As a result, metaphor-related meaning is not always realized through direct lexical correspondence in translation. Instead, it may be reformulated, redistributed across multiple units, implicitly conveyed through syntactic structure or discourse context, partially preserved, or omitted altogether. Alignment decisions in the present study are therefore made according to how metaphor-related meaning is represented in translation rather than through strict lexical matching.

Manual alignment (why: limitation of auto-alignment tools)

Pallucchini et al. (2025) argue that multilingual models still struggle with polysemy, homonymy, and language-specific semantic structures, while current alignment methods often rely on only “implicit and somewhat weak” correspondence signals between languages. Similarly, Miao et al. (2024) note that “the acquisition of token-level or word-level supervisory signals remains a challenging topic of ongoing discussion,” indicating that reliable token-level semantic alignment is still unresolved in multilingual NLP systems. Therefore, even if auto-alignment tools are involved, manual verification and correction are still required. Based on the consideration above, this study adopts manual annotation directly to ensure context-sensitive and semantically informed alignment decisions.

Alignment **Principle with Examples**

In metaphor translation, metaphor-related meaning may be realized through different translational patterns, including:

1) Direct lexical correspondence

Example:

EN: ... the more luxurious the luncheon rooms at **headquarters**, the more inefficient the business”.

ZH: 总部餐厅越豪华, 企业的运营效率就越低。”

ZH: ...先后关闭了它在台湾和南朝鲜的分厂, 而将资金转移到中国。

EN: ... **closed** its factories in Taiwan and South Korea and transferred its funds to China.

2) Paraphrastic realization

Example:

EN: ... could not expect everybody to “**goose-step**” in the same direction ...

ZH: 也不能指望所有党员都会盲目追随党的领导方向。

ZH: 于是刘庄子人打定主意: 请不着就 “抢” 。

EN: Therefore, the villagers decided: if they couldn't invite him, they would “**seize the opportunity**” themselves.

3) Distributed realization across multiple units

Example:

EN: ... financial considerations would not **stand** in the way of implementing...

ZH: ... 财政因素不会成为实施安东尼·希登 (Anthony Hidden) 提出的93项整改建议的障碍。

ZH: ... 不少农家陷入断炊困境

EN: ... **putting** them **in** a dire situation.

4) Implicit realization through syntactic structure (e.g., context needed)

Example:

EN: Nor, it seems, **is** anyone else.

ZH: 但似乎没有其他企业愿意承担全国范围内的推广任务。

5) Partial metaphorical reformulation

Example:

EN: Britain still cannot decide when to play the mandarin **game** of silence ...

ZH: 英国至今仍无法决定何时应该对中国保持沉默.....

ZH: ... 冰箱出了问题, 打个电话, 随叫随到.....

EN: ... can call for immediate assistance if their refrigerators **need repair**.

6) Omission

Example:

EN: All of which is not just a problem for a properly **penitent** British Rail: it's a problem for the government too.

ZH: 这不仅是英国铁路的问题, 更是政府的问题

ZH: ... 冰箱冷冻室容积达96升

EN: ... its 96-liter freezer capacity

Annotators need to examine the target text to determine how metaphor-related meaning is conveyed in translation using the prepared highlighted data using this guideline framework.